

Cole Richardson, Hudson Mitchell-Pullman

Republic of Slovenia

Delegation from Patrick Henry High School, San Diego, California

United Nations Security Council (B)

The Situation in Nagorno-Karabakh

Nagorno-Karabakh is a mountainous territory in the South Caucasus region bordered by the Republics of Armenia and Azerbaijan. These conflicting ethnic and religious backgrounds have caused fighting amongst citizens of Karabakh for well over a century; however, it is pertinent that we primarily focus on the recent escalation of the conflict, beginning in the late 1980s. Although Nagorno-Karabakh was under Azerbaijani control during this time, the *Council on Foreign Relations* (CFR) reported that ethnic Armenians comprised 95 percent of Karabakh's population, making it more culturally reflective of Armenia. Despite this, the Soviet Union controlled both Azerbaijan and Armenia. As the USSR declined, the Nagorno-Karabakh Autonomous Oblast (NKAO) demanded a power transfer from the Azerbaijan SSR to the Armenian SSR. The USSR refused this request, which provoked the first Nagorno-Karabakh War in February 1988. Primarily motivated by economic gain and military power, Azerbaijan engaged in aggressive military campaigns to retain control of the region despite the majority ethnic Armenian population. In April of 1991, the Azerbaijani OMON - which was essentially a paramilitary police force - launched "Operation Ring," which forcefully deported ethnic Armenians living in Nagorno-Karabakh and dramatically escalated the conflict.¹ Consequently, Armenia swiftly established a military force to defend against future Azerbaijani attacks and ethnic cleansing operations. Shortly thereafter, Nagorno-Karabakh declared itself independent from Azerbaijan, naming itself the Artsakh Republic, and Armenia seceded from the USSR to preserve its sovereignty and self-determination. Despite this, fighting between Azerbaijan and Armenia intensified, finally resulting in the Siege of Stepanakert, when Azerbaijan bombarded Nagorno-Karabakh's capital city. Just beyond Karabakh, Azerbaijan captured additional predominantly Armenian territories, displacing countless ethnic Armenians. The United Nations Security

¹ Human Rights Watch/Helsinki. *Bloodshed in the Caucasus: Escalation of the Armed Conflict in Nagorno-Karabakh*. New York: Human Rights Watch, 1992.
<https://www.hrw.org/report/1992/09/01/bloodshed-caucasus/escalation-armed-conflict-nagorno-karabakh>.

Council (UNSC) recognized the deteriorating relations between the two nations in Resolutions 822 and 874 and expressed grave concern over continued tensions in Nagorno-Karabakh and its surrounding areas. The council argued that further escalation would threaten peace and security across the region. Finally, Russia negotiated the *Bishkek Protocol* in 1994, a formal ceasefire between the Republic of Artsakh, the Republic of Armenia, and the Republic of Azerbaijan, allowing Artsakh to govern independently and calling for peace and cooperation between all involved nations.² Although this agreement formally ended fighting between the two nations, over 600,000 ethnic Azerbaijanis fled the region as a result of the conflict, settling in Azerbaijan to seek shelter and security. To manage the astronomical amount of internally displaced peoples (IDPs), Azerbaijan established twelve emergency camps, which operated for more than 15 years. The IDPs continue to live in squalor conditions, often living in tents or other structurally and environmentally unsafe conditions.³

Although there were numerous minor violations of the ceasefire, fighting between Armenia and Azerbaijan intensified at the end of September 2020. The CFR discovered that more than 7,000 soldiers and civilians were killed in a six-week conflict (recognized as the Second Nagorno-Karabakh War), which once again ended in a Russia-brokered deal enforced by 2,000 Russian peacekeepers. Azerbaijan captured much of its lost territory from the first war. Still, it did not entirely regain control of de facto independent Artsakh, which was primarily composed of ethnic Armenians since before the first war. Azerbaijan also enacted a detrimental blockade on the Lachin corridor - the only road connecting Artsakh to Armenia - on December 12th, 2020. *Amnesty International*, a prominent NGO focused on securing worldwide humanitarian aid and safety, reports that this blockade caused severe regional medical supply, food, and energy shortages, further exacerbating the already dire humanitarian crisis. This organization's director for Eastern Europe and Central Asia firmly stated, "[i]t is Azerbaijan's obligation to undertake to ensure that the population in Nagorno-Karabakh is not denied access to food and other essential goods and

² "Chronology of Events." Institute of Armenian Studies, University of Southern California. Accessed January 13, 2025. <https://dornsife.usc.edu/armenian/initiatives/resources-on-karabakh/chronology-of-events/>.

³ Tagwerker, Nathalie. "Azerbaijan Closes Last of Emergency Camps." UNHCR, February 7, 2008. <https://www.unhcr.org/news/stories/azerbaijan-closes-last-emergency-camps>.

medications.” This blockade inhibited lifesaving medical procedures, forced schools to reduce instruction significantly, and forced the Artsakh Republic government to enact a food rationing system, leaving many citizens malnourished.⁴ With the blockade still in place, Azerbaijan launched an offensive operation in Nagorno-Karabakh on September 19th, 2023, claiming that that attack was an anti-terrorist operation. Azerbaijan continued the operation in the following days, killing over 200 Armenian civilians and soldiers and regaining complete control of Nagorno-Karabakh. This offensive attack primarily resulted from combined failures by the European Union (EU), United States, Russian Federation, OSCE Minsk Group, and UNSC. Although Slovenia and most of the international community unambiguously recognize international law granting Azerbaijan control of Artsakh, using military force to regain control of the territory erodes peacemaking efforts in the region and establishes a dangerous precedent of resolving conflict through violence. Armenian Security Council Secretary Armen Grigoryan has publicly condemned Russia and its peacekeepers for failing to protect the citizens of Nagorno-Karabakh from an existential humanitarian crisis and the September invasion. These claims were echoed worldwide, citing the peacekeepers’ failure to prevent Azerbaijani attacks and apparent sabotages.⁵ Furthermore, the *National Public Radio* (NPR) reports that there were “signs of apparent progress” with Armenian-Azerbaijani relations before Azerbaijan attacked Artsakh; Western-facilitated peace talks pushed Armenia to consider formally recognizing Nagorno-Karabakh as a part of Azerbaijan, given that ethnic Armenians were guaranteed security under Azerbaijani rule. While Armenia attempted to cooperate, Baku leveraged its blockade on the Lachin corridor to stymie negotiations.⁶ The *Harvard University Davis Center for Russian and Eurasian Studies* reports that within one year of the September 19th attack, more than 100,000 ethnic Armenians had fled the region, accounting for roughly four percent of Armenia’s population. Interviewed refugees have expressed their dissatisfaction with the current

⁴ Amnesty International. “Azerbaijan: Blockade of Lachin Corridor Putting Thousands of Lives in Peril Must Be Immediately Lifted.” *Amnesty International*, February 9, 2023. <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2023/02/azerbaijan-blockade-of-lachin-corridor-putting-thousands-of-lives-in-peril-must-be-immediately-lifted/>.

⁵ Eurasianet. “Russia Rejects Criticism of Peacekeepers in Karabakh.” *Eurasianet*, January 30, 2024. <https://eurasianet.org/russia-rejects-criticism-of-peacekeepers-in-karabakh>.

⁶ Maynes, Charles. “Azerbaijan Launches Attack on Armenian Enclave Nagorno-Karabakh.” *NPR*, September 19, 2023. <https://www.npr.org/2023/09/19/1200311438/azerbaijan-armenia-nagorno-karabakh-russia>.

Armenian administration, emphasizing that Armenia's lack of support for refugees is causing mass emigration to neighboring nations with lower costs of living. More than 10,000 of the ethnic Armenians who were forced to flee Nagorno-Karabakh have already emigrated from Armenia, with many moving to Russia.⁷ Although combat has essentially stopped, the issue is far from resolved. Ethnic Armenians are angered both by their own government's inaction and Azerbaijan's damaging military operations. Likewise, Azerbaijan's president, Ilham Ilyev, has not promised to establish a viable pathway for the return of ethnic Armenians to Nagorno-Karabakh.

In 1992, the *Organization for Cooperation and Security in Europe* (OSCE) formed the Minsk Group, a unique organ of the OSCE devoted to mediating the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict, co-chaired by the Russian Federation, France, and the United States. However, while Slovenia and the European Union firmly support the OSCE's efforts, the program has grown increasingly futile. Achieving the Madrid Principles is likely impossible, and Azerbaijan has denounced and refused to cooperate with the group following its 2023 offensive. Although the Minsk Group has not yet been officially dissolved, Armenia's president has agreed to formally disband the organization in exchange for bilaterally normalized relations with Azerbaijan.⁸ The EU and Slovenia have initiated peacemaking efforts with Armenia and Azerbaijan, reaffirming our commitment to peaceful conflict resolution. Specifically, the EU passed the Eastern Partnership Policy Beyond 2020 agreement to foster closer relations with South Caucasus nations. Unfortunately, EU members have failed to unite and form a cohesive response to Azerbaijan's recent aggression, resulting in a primarily lackluster reaction. Further, while the EU's neutral position has avoided further conflict escalation, it has made the union's efforts largely ineffective.⁹ Slovenia and the EU unequivocally support Azerbaijan's territorial integrity over Nagorno-Karabakh, emphasizing that

⁷ "Nagorno-Karabakh: Armenia, Azerbaijan Trade Accusations Amid September Offensive." *Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty*, September 19, 2023.

<https://www.rferl.org/a/nagorno-karabakh-armenia-azerbaijan-september-offensive/33125293.html>.

⁸ Krikorian, Onnik James. "From Key West to Key Failures: The Demise of the OSCE Minsk Group." *Commonspace.eu*, January 14, 2025.

⁹ Panahova, Lamiya. "Recognition of the EU's Actorness in the Karabakh Peace Process by Azerbaijan." *Problems of Post-Communism*, August 19, 2024. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10758216.2024.2380329>.

Nagorno-Karabakh and its surrounding territories belong to Azerbaijan. However, our delegation also highlights the importance of a diplomatic and peaceful resolution to the conflict, upholding the fundamental human rights of ethnic Armenians and IDPs.

In addition to diplomatic tensions between the two nations, there are frequent strifes between ethnic Armenians, who are predominantly Christian, and primarily Muslim Azerbaijanis. Following the first Nagorno-Karabakh War, both Armenia and Azerbaijan forcibly displaced the other population. However, Azerbaijan has engaged in purposeful and blatant ethnic cleansing - which the UN recognizes as a crime against humanity - since the second war, endangering hundreds of thousands of ethnic Armenians. While there is no unambiguous definition of ethnic cleansing, the United Nations defines it as a “purposeful policy designed by one ethnic or religious group to remove by violent and terror-inspiring means the civilian population of another ethnic or religious group from certain geographic areas.”

At the 2005 UN World Summit, Slovenia signed the *Right to Protect* (R2P) doctrine, mandating that all states protect populations from genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and ethnic cleansing. Slovenian President Nataša Pirc Musar reiterates the imperativeness of the R2P, stating that “[w]hile States have a primary responsibility to protect the population on their territory, the international community holds a shared responsibility to protect vulnerable groups from the worst violations of their universal human rights.” Slovenia proudly honors this international commitment and demands the UNSC’s unequivocal support of the R2P doctrine, especially concerning the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict.¹⁰ The *Helsinki Citizens Assembly*, a local NGO that published a comprehensive study on the ethnic cleansing of Armenians from Nagorno-Karabakh beginning in 2020, reports that “the Azerbaijani state ethnically cleansed Nagorno-Karabakh of its ethnic Armenian population, using forced displacement as a means.” Regrettably, the UN has not acted under the R2P in Nagorno-Karabakh because of Russia’s veto power, which it would almost certainly invoke if the matter were presented to the council.¹¹ Moreover,

¹⁰ Global Centre for the Responsibility to Protect. “*What Is R2P?*” Accessed January 26, 2025. <https://www.globalr2p.org/what-is-r2p/>.

¹¹ Yunusov, Arif. “Ethnic Cleansing Is Happening in Nagorno-Karabakh. How Can the World Respond?” *Council on Foreign Relations*, October 6, 2023. <https://www.cfr.org/article/ethnic-cleansing-happening-nagorno-karabakh-how-can-world-respond>.

Azerbaijan has removed ethnic Armenian inscriptions across the region and has transformed the former Artsakh State University into Azerbaijan-run Karabakh University. In 2021, the *International Court of Justice* (ICJ) ruled that Azerbaijan must “[t]ake all necessary measures to prevent and punish acts of vandalism and desecration affecting Armenian cultural heritage, including but not limited to churches and other places of worship, monuments, landmarks, cemeteries and artifacts.” However, the *Caucasus Heritage Watch* (CHW), an academic organization supported by Cornell University, reports that Azerbaijan demolished a sacred 19th-century church in Nagorno-Karabakh, an evident violation of this ruling.¹² Azerbaijan has repeatedly exploited Armenia’s comparably weak military, forcing Armenia to shift its attention away from protecting the impoverished IDPs across the country. Slovenia emphasizes the importance of engaging in diplomatic discussions to provide humanitarian aid and refuge to IDPs while protecting Azerbaijan’s territorial integrity.

The severe animosity between ethnic Armenians and Azerbaijanis is worsening the dispute in Nagorno-Karabakh. Therefore, if we solely rely on global diplomatic efforts through the UN and large diplomacy conferences, which are often futile, we will never achieve peaceful coexistence. Instead, we must supplement these broad initiatives with effective regional strategies, including utilizing local NGOs, humanitarian assistance, and widespread education and healthcare. Firstly, the delegation of Slovenia urges the council to address foreign interference and coercion with Azerbaijan and Armenia, which inhibits peaceful coexistence and cooperation. Russia supplies 94 and 60 percent of Armenian and Azerbaijani arms imports, respectively. In addition to Russia, Türkiye and its close political allies have strongly supported aggressive Azerbaijani military attacks to regain control of Nagorno-Karabakh and its surrounding territories. Türkiye hopes that Azerbaijan’s renewed control of Nagorno-Karabakh will enable new infrastructure projects that connect Azerbaijan to Türkiye, bolstering trade by establishing

¹² Caucasus Heritage Watch. “Azerbaijani Forces Launch New Military Operation in Nagorno-Karabakh.” *Cornell University Caucasus Heritage Watch*, September 19, 2023. <https://caucasusheritage.cornell.edu/?p=1588>.

direct routes.¹³ Slovenia affirms that because Azerbaijan and Armenia are unwilling to cooperate with the OSCE Minsk group, we must form a reconciliation body that hosts regular roundtable discussions between the two nations, overseen by impartial moderators from the UN. However, disputes between Armenia and Azerbaijan, foreign interference, and prolonged disagreements may impede these discussions. Hence, the neutral body must enact surveillance measures in Azerbaijan through local NGOs, the UN Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), satellites, and the UNHCR, documenting potential instances of further ethnic cleansing and mistreatment of remaining ethnic Armenians and their property. This ensures the humane treatment and protection of ethnic Armenians while a resolution is reached between the two opposing parties. The moderators should systematically urge Azerbaijan and Armenia to normalize relations, establish open lines of communication, and reasonably eliminate foreign interference in Nagorno-Karabakh. Slovenia believes that we cannot adequately address ethnic cleansing, IDPs, and the humanitarian crisis in Armenia and Nagorno-Karabakh without cooperation.¹⁴

Furthermore, in light of Russia's unprovoked invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Slovenia and the EU must become increasingly involved in matters of democracy, security, and defense in Armenia. Although Armenia remains an ally of Russia, the EU has gradually broadened its influence over the region, marked by the deployment of "EU observers" noting the state of democracy in Armenia. Slovenia acknowledges Armenia's apparent progress with democratization and governmental reform, providing Armenian citizens with a better livelihood and increased freedoms. Although Slovenia and Armenia are geographically dissimilar, Slovenia shares a tumultuous history with communism, similar to Armenia, demonstrating our ability to democratize the nation given our historical backgrounds. In 2023, Armenian President Pashinyan pledged to align Armenia with European values, enacting a viable pathway to EU membership.

¹³ Ramani, Samuel. "How the End of Nagorno-Karabakh Will Reshape Geopolitics." *Foreign Policy*, October 25, 2023. Accessed February 5, 2025.

<https://foreignpolicy.com/2023/10/25/armenia-azerbaijan-nagorno-karabakh-turkey-iran-russia-europe/>.

¹⁴Google Notebook LM. Prompt: How could a neutral moderator's roundtable discussion help normalize relations and establish relations between Azerbaijan and Armenia? What pushback would this receive? How could we ensure that the efforts are fruitful? What role will Slovenia and the EU play? February 5, 2025.

<https://notebooklm.google.com>

Slovenia reaffirms that strengthening relations with the EU and potentially gaining EU membership will offer Armenia the opportunity to provide adequate refuge and aid to ethnic Armenians from Nagorno-Karabakh. Slovenia recommends the creation of a council comprising European and other Western nations to offer governmental assistance, expert advice on democracy, and humanitarian aid to Armenia.¹⁵ Upholding democracy in Armenia is mutually beneficial for the EU and Armenian citizens, demonstrating the importance of EU aid in Armenia and Nagorno-Karabakh. The EU must expand its funding to support this council in engaging in diplomatic missions to assist the Armenian government in supporting democracy.¹⁶

Additionally, the council must partner with the UNHCR, which reports that 15 percent of the 100,000 Karabakh refugees have disabilities, and roughly two-thirds are women or children. In October 2023, the UNHCR requested \$97 million to support emergency refugee response programs in Armenia. The EU has also mobilized 67 million euros to help Armenian refugees, enacting social programs such as local protection systems, support for small businesses, and offering legal aid to IDPs. Given the astronomical number of Armenians who have emigrated out of Armenia for a lower cost of living, the EU and UNCHR must also invest in providing affordable housing opportunities to Armenians, especially those who were forcibly displaced because of the conflict in Nagorno-Karabakh.¹⁷ Furthermore, these organizations should invest in education and vocational training initiatives for multidimensionally impoverished and disadvantaged populations, enabling new careers that reduce dependence on Russia and increase domestic production. In 2023, Armenia's information technology sector grew by 43 percent compared to the prior year, demonstrating its recent exponential growth. However, when we analyze recent IT job *creation* in Armenia, we can see that the graph has primarily plateaued, indicating that the

¹⁵ Kostanyan, Hrant. "Armenia's Slow Drift Toward the EU." Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, January 2025. <https://carnegieendowment.org/russia- Eurasia/politika/2025/01/armenia-eu-drift?lang=en>.

¹⁶ "Armenian, French Foreign Ministers Discuss Regional Security Issues." Armenpress, February 6, 2024. <https://armenpress.am/en/article/1199889>.

¹⁷ European External Action Service. "European Union Launches New Civil Society Actions in Support of Refugees in Armenia." February 5, 2024. European External Action Service. https://www.eeas.europa.eu/delegations/armenia/european-union-launches-new-civil-society-actions-support-refugees-armenia_en.

sector has become more productive.¹⁸ To strengthen the domestic economy, the EU should invest in specific career development programs for IT aimed at doubling the number of IT workers to nearly 70,000 by 2040, representing an annual five percent increase in IT employment.

When ethnic Armenians were displaced from Nagorno-Karabakh, they had to abandon their studies at the Artsakh State University. When Azerbaijan reclaimed the university, 3,000 ethnic Armenians were actively enrolled, causing severe disruptions to their education. The UNHCR reports that many of the refugees from Nagorno-Karabakh are hosted in a small village just outside of the Armenian capital, Yerevan, called the town of Marsis. This town lacks career and vocational education besides agricultural training, inhibiting many refugees from entering the IT sector. To account for this loss in educational opportunity, the EU should partner with the *Armenian Educational Foundation* to build an educational institute in the refugee community to educate refugees in IT and other productive sectors. The UNHCR should also collaborate with the agricultural university in Marsis to provide free education to refugees from Nagorno-Karabakh, further expanding Armenia's agriculture sector. To further support Armenian refugees, we must address their mental and physical well-being. The *World Health Organization* (WHO) established mental health programs in Armenia in 2023, but funding for these services stopped primarily at the beginning of 2024, leaving many Armenians still vulnerable. The WHO and EU must form a partnership with Armenia to foster a community-based mental health approach, which has been proven to lessen the severity and frequency of mental health crises. This should include regular mental health screenings and education to minimize the stigma surrounding mental health care, promoting inclusive communities, psychologists to help refugees cope with past traumatic experiences, and solving significant societal issues such as housing affordability and job availability.

In 2023, the ICJ ruled that Azerbaijan must allow Armenians to safely return to Nagorno-Karabakh without persecution or discrimination. Unfortunately, Azerbaijan has not respected this ruling, and the international community has failed to act under the R2P doctrine and intervene.

¹⁸ Modex. "Information Technology Sector in Armenia (2023)." *Modex*, 2024.
<https://modex.am/en/information-technology-sector-in-armenia-2023-2/>.

Slovenia urges the international community to unambiguously condemn Azerbaijan for ethnic cleansing, defacing Armenian heritage sites, censoring independent media criticizing its response in Nagorno-Karabakh, and failing to adhere to the 2023 ICJ ruling. In September of 2024, two Armenian victims filed a complaint against Azerbaijan to the *International Criminal Court* (ICC), citing crimes committed under the Rome Statute, such as crimes against humanity and ethnic cleansing. Although Azerbaijan is not a member of the ICC, significantly limiting the effectiveness of legal action, the UNSC must immediately provide the ICC and all other legal bodies with all relevant information regarding Azerbaijan's 2020 and 2023 offensive operations.

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<https://www.ictj.org/latest-news/complaint-filed-icc-prosecutor-year-after-forced-displacement-armenians-nagorno>.

Topic B: The Situation in Afghanistan

Section 1

The situation in Afghanistan has been one of the most tragic and long-lasting humanitarian crises in history; spanning back decades prior to the takeover by the Taliban in 2021 following the removal of United States troops and the subsequent fleeing of top Afghan officials to Uzbekistan. Political instability has marred Afghanistan for nearly two centuries. A series of attempted foreign invasions and interventions from world powers such as the United Kingdom, United States, and the Soviet Union has created a cycle of new autocratic governments swooping in to fill the power vacuum without a majority of the people backing them, leading to more unrest and the toppling of the new government, which is quickly replaced by yet another autocratic and unpopular regime. Although periods of peace have occurred, the longest only lasted around 40 years from the early 1930s to the 1973 Coup, and the nation has remained unstable and riddled with war since.¹⁹

Afghanistan is a very diverse nation; holding many different ethnic and religious groups. The Taliban is primarily Pashtun, and has massacred non-Pashtun ethnic groups in the past, but they have begun giving Uzbeks, Tajiks, and Hazaras, the three next-largest ethnic groups, some meager political power. Fear of protests and ethnic violence has led the Taliban to become less discriminatory. The Taliban is an extremely centralized government that has little desire to

¹⁹ [The Collapse of Afghanistan | Journal of Democracy](#)

distribute its power. Many groups, such as the Shia and other religious minorities, receive virtually no representation, but still maintain power in local governments.²⁰

Afghanistan is “one of the world’s most urgent crises”, according to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR). 23.7 million Afghans are in need of humanitarian assistance, 14.8 million suffer from acute food insecurity, 10.9 million are displaced, and 3.5 million children are malnourished.²¹ While these figures are shocking, one might be surprised to find out that Afghanistan is not suffering from any major food shortages, save from some farmers losing their crops due to climate issues. The root of this crisis lies in the collapse of the Afghan economy. According to the UNDP, “Approximately 85 percent of Afghans live on less than one dollar a day”.²² Prior to the exiting of US troops and the Taliban takeover in 2021, Afghanistan’s economy was extremely dependent on foreign assistance. This assistance abruptly stopped coming when the US and World Bank pulled out of the nation. This caused the Afghan Central Bank to collapse and cost most Afghans almost all of their purchasing power. The Taliban created the Da Central Bank (DAB) as a replacement, but it has been effectively barred from the World Bank, meaning the bank cannot do business with international partners and often cannot access funds from humanitarian organizations. NGOs have also largely stopped providing Afghanistan with aid due to the Taliban’s human rights abuses. While falling food prices and a growing Gross Domestic Product (GDP) present a positive outlook for Afghanistan's economy, these changes have done little to recoup the massive losses the nation experienced three years ago.²³

²⁰ [Afghanistan's Ethnic Faultlines Under Taliban Rule - Centre for Strategic and Contemporary Research](#)

²¹ [Afghanistan situation | Global Focus](#)

²² ["Approximately 85 percent of Afghans live on less than one dollar a day." | United Nations Development Programme](#)

²³ [Afghanistan Development Update December 2024](#)

The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) has been active in Afghanistan for over 20 years, but since the Taliban takeover in 2021 it has been very ineffective in helping the nation. The UN's refusal to recognize the Taliban as the legitimate government of Afghanistan and the Taliban's desire to control the flow of humanitarian aid has left the UNAMA impotent against Afghanistan's decline. UNAMA's success is critical for ensuring the future of Afghanistan. UNAMA's calls for improved human rights standards and the thorough investigation of human rights abuses in Afghanistan have been largely ignored by the Taliban, who have made little effort to preserve their international image.²⁴ While the Taliban did meet with UN officials in July of 2024, signifying some progress in international relations, little has come from the event and the Taliban remains unrecognized.²⁵

One of the most pressing issues within Afghanistan is the Taliban's treatment of women. Initially, there was hope that the Taliban would reform and be more open to protecting women's rights, but these hopes were quickly proven wrong. Education is prohibited for women over 12 years old, women must be fully covered at all times, women are not permitted to raise their voices or sing in public, and they must be accompanied by a male chaperone when traveling.[^] Currently, 80% of Afghanistan's school age girls are being intentionally deprived of any access to education.²⁶ In March of 2024 an edict was made permitting the stoning of women who committed adultery.²⁷

²⁴ [United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan](#)

²⁵ [Doha Meeting on Afghanistan Provides Critical Opportunity to Discuss Women's Rights, Speaker Tells Security Council](#)

²⁶ [Taliban's Relentless Assault on Afghan Women's Bodies, Autonomy | Human Rights Watch](#)

²⁷ [In Afghanistan, women are once again facing death by stoning for adultery : NPR](#)

As the situation in Afghanistan worsened, many Afghans fled to their neighbor Pakistan. Currently, Pakistan holds over 2.5 million displaced Afghans.²⁸ This influx of refugees has fueled a series of border clashes. Tensions have risen recently as the terrorist cell known as the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), or simply the Pakistani Taliban, conducted a series of attacks on Pakistani border posts. Pakistan has alleged that the Taliban has been aiding this group, yet nothing has been confirmed. In late December of 2024 a Pakistani airstrike dropped into Eastern Afghanistan reportedly killed 46 people. Pakistan claims those targeted were members of the TTP, whereas the Taliban claims women and children were among those killed. Currently tensions are at an all-time high, yet considering how both nations are dealing with a myriad of internal issues, a full scale border war seems unlikely.²⁹

The refusal of many international organizations to provide any assistance or even negotiate with the Taliban due to their human rights abuses has made it very challenging for any real progress to be made.

Section 2

In March of 2024, the representative of the Republic of Slovenia to the UN made an address to the Security Council on the situation in Afghanistan. In this address Slovenia calls for “a coherent and structured engagement on Afghanistan with the aim of helping the Afghan people, bringing stability, prosperity and sustainable peace”, as well as “ full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of women and girls in all spheres of public life, their right to education, employment and work, as well as their freedom of movement, expression and assembly”. Slovenia condemns the ongoing human rights abuses in Afghanistan which have continued

²⁸ [Islamic Republic of Pakistan | Global Focus](#)

²⁹ [Tensions between Pakistan and Afghanistan escalate amid border clashes - The Washington Post](#)

despite the nation being a party to several human rights treaties, specifically the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW). Slovenia, as a member of the European Union (EU), affirms that the recognition of the Taliban as the legitimate government of Afghanistan cannot occur until the Taliban fulfills certain international obligations, namely addressing their human rights abuses. Slovenia is directly involved with humanitarian efforts in Afghanistan, financially supporting the Mine Detection Polyclinic in Kabul.³⁰

Slovenia is a staunch supporter of UNAMA, and voted to renew its mandate last March. Slovenia “commend(s) UNAMA for all the activities it has been consistently undertaking in implementing its mandate”, emphasizing, “UNAMA’s work in the fields of human rights, humanitarian assistance and continued political dialogue with the Taliban”. Above all else, Slovenia is committed to helping the people of Afghanistan, especially the women and girls whose freedom has been severely oppressed by the Taliban.³¹ According to the Gender Inequality Index (GII), as of 2022 Slovenia ranked 13th with a GII of .049, meaning it is the 13th most gender-equal country in the world. Slovenia is deeply committed to protecting the rights of women in all facets of life. Women account for 35.6% of Slovenia’s National Council, its main legislative body, and receive secondary school education at almost the exact same rate as men. Conversely, Afghanistan ranked 162nd with a GII of .665.³²

In January of 2023, Slovenia welcomed in 27 Afghan nationals from Turkey, granting them refugee status, providing them with accommodations, and giving them pathways towards

³⁰ [Statement on the situation in Afghanistan - Building Trust](#)

³¹ [Explanation of vote on a UN SC resolution renewing UNAMA's mandate - Building Trust](#)

³² [Gender Inequality Index \(GII\)](#)

integration into Slovenian society. Slovenia believes resettlement can be a way to demonstrate solidarity, as well as a method to reduce incentives for smuggling and human trafficking.³³

In September of 2024, Slovenia's Minister of Foreign and European Affairs, Tanja Majon, affirmed at a Security Council debate on the topic of Afghanistan that, "The future of any country, including Afghanistan, cannot be prosperous unless it is inclusive".³⁴

Section 3

For any solutions to be effective in truly helping the Afghan people and creating permanent change, some level of cooperation must occur between the governments of the world and the de-facto government of Afghanistan. The use of international recognition as a form of leverage has not proved to be effective in getting the Taliban to cease its human rights abuses, and further sanctioning the nation, which has already been barred from most international trade and is in an economic crisis, would do nothing more than exacerbate the issue at hand by further depriving the Afghan people of resources and would be unlikely to get the Taliban to improve their human rights standards, seeing as previous sanctions have failed. Therefore, we must find other ways to approach this situation without recognition. The historic meeting between UN officials and Taliban leaders in Doha shows that collaboration is possible even without fully recognizing the Taliban. Solutions must be centered around helping the people of Afghanistan rather than focusing on political issues which if solved would do little to immediately better the lives of the tens of millions who are being affected by this crisis. Immediate aid must be given to the millions at risk of famine and to the women who have been so deeply oppressed under Taliban rule. Only after these lives have been saved with their freedoms restored should the

³³ [Slovenia accepts refugees under the resettlement project | GOV.SI](#)

³⁴ [FM Fajon: Slovenia will always be the voice of the oppressed women and girls in Afghanistan - Building Trust](#)

Security Council begin helping create the frameworks for a long-term plan to stabilize Afghanistan.

The delegation of Slovenia urges its fellow member states to continue to supply aid to local NGOs within Afghanistan. Currently the United States maintains hold on over 4 billion USD within the Fund for Afghan People, and has continually added to this fund since 2022. These funds came from assets which were frozen following the Taliban takeover in 2021, The United States has refused to allow this money to be used for humanitarian aid out of fear of the Taliban misappropriating the funds.³⁵ Slovenia proposes that the Security Council order any member states who are currently in possession of any assets seized from the Afghanistan Central Bank to use these assets to purchase necessary humanitarian supplies, such as food, water, or first aid supplies, to be distributed into Afghanistan. By sending in supplies rather than the money itself, this reduces the chance of the Taliban possibly misusing funds.

Slovenia proposes the creation of a Security Council working group named the Working Group on Bolstering Afghanistan Industries to help revitalize the Afghan economy by aiding in infrastructure projects such as: constructing oil refineries in its northern regions, creating jobs for local Afghan citizens and reducing reliance on oil imports, giving aid to farmers to help increase cotton production, which has fallen dramatically since 2021, and providing training to other workers in Afghanistan.

Slovenia additionally urges for an amendment to be made to the current UNAMA mandate which would require UNAMA to host quarterly meetings with Taliban officials in different nations which border Afghanistan. The meeting place would be decided by each member state, and the responsibility would rotate after each meeting. However, these meetings would not come with any form of international recognition. As a leader in women's rights,

³⁵ [The Taliban have no legal right to multibillion dollar Afghan fund, says US watchdog](#)

Slovenia hopes to be able to send diplomats to these meetings, so that the Taliban may be educated on gender equality. Slovenia recognizes that this may be a slow and challenging process, but knows that in order for Afghanistan to take its place in the global stage, it must change its policies.